CHAPTER 7 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Shiloh

In two days in Tennessee, more Americans fell than in all the nation's earlier wars combined. April 1862.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

In two days in Tennessee, more Americans fell than in all the nation's earlier wars combined. April 1862.

How do you make sense of a number so large it stops feeling like people?

A Surprise at Dawn

APRIL 1862 · THE WEST

While the East grabbed headlines, the war in the West — the Mississippi Valley — would decide the Confederacy's fate. There, a Union general named Ulysses S. Grant was driving south into Tennessee.

On the morning of April 6, 1862, Confederate forces burst out of the woods near a small church called Shiloh and caught Grant's army by surprise. The fighting raged for two days in the woods, fields, and peach orchards.

"Battle of Shiloh, April 6, 1862" — chromolithograph, McCormick Harvesting Machine Co., c. 1888, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Battle of Shiloh

APRIL 6, 1862

Later artists painted Shiloh as orderly and grand. The men who fought there described something closer to chaos — a "Hornet's Nest" of fire where whole units simply vanished.

"Battle of Shiloh, April 6, 1862" — chromolithograph, McCormick Harvesting Machine Co., c. 1888, public domain (Library of Congress).

23,000

THE ARITHMETIC OF SHILOH

Grant held on, counterattacked on the second day, and won — but the cost stunned the country. In two days, roughly 23,000 men were killed, wounded, captured, or missing.

That single battle produced more American casualties than the Revolution, the War of 1812, and the Mexican-American War combined. And it was only April 1862. The war had years left to run.

The divided nation, 1861 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

ULYSSES S. GRANT, REMEMBERING SHILOH

I saw an open field … so covered with dead that it would have been possible to walk across the clearing, in any direction, stepping on dead bodies, without a foot touching the ground.

The End of Illusions — Again

WHAT THE NUMBERS MEANT

Shiloh ended any lingering hope that the war would be short or clean. Grant later wrote that after Shiloh he “gave up all idea of saving the Union except by complete conquest.”

The battle also proved the Union strategy in the West was working — Grant kept pushing toward the Mississippi River. But the price revealed the true nature of this war: industrial-scale death, counted in the tens of thousands, again and again.

The divided nation, 1861 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

Make the Numbers Speak

YOUR TURN

You'll work with the casualty data from Shiloh and earlier American wars, and practice the skill of turning raw numbers into a historical argument.